

Ethical Dilemmas in Genetic Testing - Factoid Sheet

Week 4 - Thursday - Holistic Patient Care 12 - current faculty deck + official Week 4 objectives

Master rule: genetic information is durable, predictive, familial, and sensitive - so establish ethically valid consent and confidentiality before testing or disclosure.

Why Genetic Testing Is Different

- May predict future disease before symptoms and with variable penetrance.
- A result in one person may reveal risk in biologic relatives.
- Stored DNA can be reused, reinterpreted, or sought by third parties.
- Results can affect psychology, reproduction, privacy, and social decisions.

CGD Case Anchor

DHR absent + Aspergillus + affected maternal males → CGD strongly suspected. Molecular testing can distinguish multiple candidate genes/inheritance patterns, guide counseling, and support gene-specific therapy.

Consent

Deck emphasis: informed consent addressing benefits and risks is prerequisite for clinical and research genetic testing. Usual decision-maker = patient or authorized parent/legal guardian.

If Consent Was Violated

Stop unauthorized use/disclosure and begin with the institutional ethics process highlighted in the deck.

Major Ethical Domains

Domain	Question
Access	Who can afford accredited testing?
Psychological	Does the patient want predictive information?
Family	Who should know / who should tell?
Privacy	Who can access results or stored DNA?
Reproduction	How will carrier or prenatal information be used?

Genetic Testing Ethics - First-Step Logic

Vignette Framework

1. Identify the exact decision and urgency. 2. Identify who has authority to consent. 3. Confirm informed consent/preferences. 4. Protect confidentiality. 5. Use genetics/ethics consultation when conflict persists.

Common Scenarios

Cue	First move
Consent unclear before testing	Do not test yet; clarify authority and obtain consent
Family demands result	Check authorization/confidentiality before disclosure
Relative may be at risk	Counsel patient about familial implications; do not automatically disclose
Unauthorized test already occurred	Institutional ethics process

GINA - Course Scope

Lecture highlights protection against genetic-information discrimination in **health insurance and employment**. Do not expand that automatically to every insurance/social context.

Stored DNA

Ask whether the original consent covers later testing, research, commercial use, third-party access, or legal/genealogic use.

Must-Not-Miss

Benefit does not erase autonomy. Family relevance does not automatically erase confidentiality. Predictive information can harm as well as help. In ethics vignettes, establish valid decision-making before testing, disclosure, or contacting relatives.

Study note: this sheet summarizes the faculty deck’s ethical framework for course purposes; it is not legal advice.